Tacto: The First Customers

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MODULE 08 · FINDING FIRST USERS · CASE, READ BEFORE CLASS

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In late September 2020, André Petry and his two co-founders ran a young Munich company with fresh money, a website and no customer on record. Tacto Technology GmbH had been entered in the commercial register of the Munich district court that summer, with Petry, Johannes Groll and Nico Bentenrieder as its managing directors.[1] On 7 September 2020 the startup news site deutsche-startups.de reported that Visionaries Club and UVC Partners had invested in Tacto. The amount was not disclosed.[2] Tacto's own site described Visionaries Club as a Berlin-based fund and UVC Partners, short for Unternehmertum Venture Capital Partners, as a Munich- and Berlin-based one.[3] The website promised "autonomous procurement", software to take routine work off the hands of procurement teams. It showed no product, no price and no customer, and it ended with the line "Interested in what we are building? Get in touch via hello@tacto.ai".[4] [5]

Petry later described what the founders were doing around that first round of funding. "We concentrated only on building the first product version for now, or rather on winning the first customers," he recalled in 2023. The money had not been the hard part. "The difficulty wasn't raising the capital, the difficulty was winning the first customers, building the first product and so on."[6] [7]

Whom should the founders ask first to become those customers, and what should they ask them for?

Purchasing in 2020

Petry, Groll and Bentenrieder started early in 2020. "We started early in 2020 and then talked with a wide range of Mittelstand firms," Petry recalled in 2023, using the German word for small and medium-sized companies.[8] Petry recalled that the founders saw two areas in industry, the supply chain and production. "Of course at the start of Corona, with all the supply chains, breakdowns or rather shortages, it quickly became clear that this was a topic," Petry said.[9]

The website of September 2020 described the problem in its own words. "Strategic procurement today needs to be efficient, resilient, and sustainable – but drowns in transactional activities. Ever-increasing complexity in terms of parts, suppliers, and supply chains as well as lacking internal and external data transparency requires novel solutions to drive competitive advantage." Tacto promised to "support procurement teams to focus on what matters by automating what does not."[4]

Other startups were working on the topic too, by one observer's account. On the day the investment became public, one of the two hosts of deutsche-startups.de's Insider podcast said that procurement was "certainly a big topic" and that he had "seen quite a few startups in recent weeks and months that revolve around this topic in the broadest sense".[10]

Three Founders from TUM

The About page of September 2020 introduced the three founders in a few lines each (Exhibit 2). Petry had “a background in Management & Informatics” and had helped enterprises “to digitally transform their operations at BCG and appliedAI, where he worked on leveraging AI in procurement”. Groll had “an Electrical Engineering background” and had helped industrial enterprises at Palantir “become data-savvy and automate business-critical workflows”. Bentenrieder had “a background in Informatics & Industrial Engineering” and “got a first-hand impression of the challenges around sourcing thousands of different car parts while working at BMW for over three years”.[3]

All three were alumni of the Center for Digital Technology and Management (CDTM) in Munich, Groll from the class of fall 2016, Petry and Bentenrieder from the class of fall 2017.[11] In Tacto’s written answers to Munich Startup in June 2022, the founders said they had met during their studies at TUM, at UnternehmerTUM and at CDTM, three Munich institutions whose practical projects and programmes they had taken part in, and that the company had begun “in a small lab at TU München”.[12] “Every one of us even comes from AI research at TU Munich,” Petry told a procurement audience in 2021.[13] The same written answers of 2022 said that before founding, the three had already supported Mittelstand firms in digitalisation and purchasing projects.[12]

The founders first planned to apply for EXIST, “a funding programme here”, as Petry put it in 2022. Two entrepreneurs they had long been in contact with, Michael Wax, a co-founder of the logistics company Forto, and Hanno Renner, a co-founder of the HR software company Personio, advised them otherwise. “They advised us, hey, I think it makes much more sense, we’ll support you too, if you do a [...] financing right away. We did that back then with Visionaries and UVC and business angels, because that way we could simply get to market faster,” Petry recalled.[14]

Money, Investors and the Website

According to North Data’s summary of the commercial register, the company was entered in July 2020 as Tactum Technology GmbH, with a share capital of €25,002, and by late August 2020 the register showed the name Tacto Technology GmbH, a new address and a share capital of €30,165 (Exhibit 1).[1] The first financing round came “around mid-2020”, Petry recalled, when “we were still very, very early”. The investment process came almost in passing, out of the sparring the founders had done with Visionaries Club, UVC, Wax and Renner.[7] [6]

The About page named the investors in their own words. Visionaries Club was “a Berlin-based early stage VC fund backed by leading European digital founders and family business entrepreneurs”. UVC Partners offered “strategic and operational support, as well as access to a vast network of corporate partners, experienced industry experts and international follow-on investors”. The business angels were Hanno Renner of Personio, Johannes Reck of GetYourGuide, Torsten Reil of NaturalMotion and Michael Wax of Forto.[3]

Tacto’s written account of 2022 also said that “in the early phase” the founders had spoken with more than 400 experts and users along the entire supply chain of an industrial company “to understand the problem very well”. It did not date these conversations or say how many were with buyers.[12]

On 23 September 2020 the website consisted of a home page, an About page with a jobs section, an imprint and a privacy page (Exhibit 2). It described an engine that would be “Flexible to fit your needs”, “Intelligent to deliver while improving” and “Autonomous to do more with less”. It showed no product screen, no price and no customer or partner name. The About page asked “passionate

people in all departments" to write to the same address, and the imprint listed the company's VAT number as still to follow ("wird nachgereicht").[4] [3] [15] The public record does not show whether any firm had agreed to work with Tacto by then.

The First Customers

The founders' task, in Petry's later words, was to win the first customers while they built the first version of the product.[6] Two choices came with it.

The first was whom to ask first. The founders could start with firms and people they already knew, the Mittelstand firms they had supported in projects before founding and the firms they had talked with since early 2020. They could ask their investors and business angels for introductions, to the digital founders and family business entrepreneurs behind Visionaries Club or to UVC's corporate partners and industry experts, as Tacto's About page described them. Or they could write to heads of purchasing at industrial Mittelstand firms they had never spoken with, the procurement teams the website said Tacto was building for.

The second was what to ask for. Without a product to show, the founders could ask a firm for its time and its feedback on what Tacto would build. Or they could ask for money from the first conversation. In that case they would have to name a price, because none had been published.

Late September 2020

In late September 2020, Petry and his co-founders had funding, the networks of two funds and four business angels, a website, the firms they had talked with, and no customer on record. Petry would later call winning the first customers the difficulty of that phase. Whom should the founders ask first, and what should they ask them for?

Exhibit 1: Tacto, January to September 2020

Date	Event
Early 2020	The founders start, by Petry's account of 2023
23 June 2020	Articles of association dated
16 July 2020	Entry in the commercial register, Amtsgericht München HRB 257852, as Tactum Technology GmbH, share capital €25,002, managing directors André Petry, Nico Bentenrieder and Johannes Groll
Mid-2020	First financing round, by Petry's account of 2023
22 August 2020	Name Tacto Technology GmbH, new address, share capital €30,165
24 August 2020	New shareholder list filed
7 September 2020	deutsche-startups.de reports the investment by Visionaries Club and UVC Partners, amount not disclosed
9 September 2020	Wordmark "tacto" listed
23 September 2020	First archived capture of the website tacto.ai

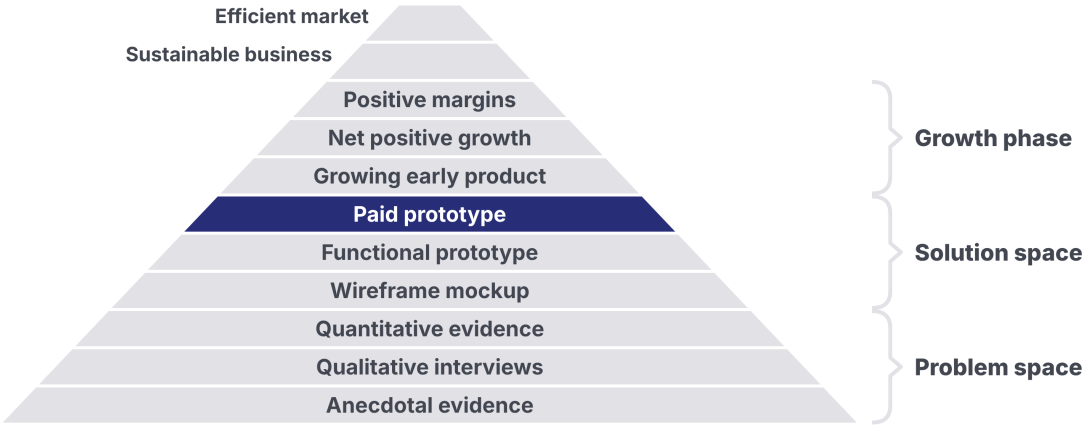
Source: compiled by the case writer from the register summary of North Data and the GLEIF record, deutsche-startups.de and the Internet Archive, see notes [1], [2] and [4]. The register dates come from North Data's automated summary of the register, not from the register originals. GLEIF gives 15 July 2020 as the entity's creation date, one day earlier. The two "by Petry's account" rows are his recollections of 2023, see notes [8] and [7].

Exhibit 2: What tacto.ai Showed on 23 September 2020

Page	What it said, verbatim
Home, headline	“Autonomous procurement. Intelligent automation at your fingertips. Building the next generation procurement engine”
Home, problem	“Strategic procurement today needs to be efficient, resilient, and sustainable – but drowns in transactional activities. Ever-increasing complexity in terms of parts, suppliers, and supply chains as well as lacking internal and external data transparency requires novel solutions to drive competitive advantage.”
Home, promise	“We support procurement teams to focus on what matters by automating what does not.” “Flexible to fit your needs. Intelligent to deliver while improving. Autonomous to do more with less”
Home, call to action	“Interested in what we are building? Get in touch via hello@tacto.ai”
About, mission	“We founded tacto to build a customer-first solution that helps procurement teams to focus on what matters by automating what does not.”
About, Nico Bentenrieder, Engineering & Development	“Nico has a background in Informatics & Industrial Engineering. He got a first-hand impression of the challenges around sourcing thousands of different car parts while working at BMW for over three years.”
About, Johannes Groll, Product & Data	“Johannes has an Electrical Engineering background. In the past, at Palantir he helped industrial enterprises become data-savvy and automate business-critical workflows.”
About, André Petry, Business & Operations	“André has a background in Management & Informatics. He helped enterprises to digitally transform their operations at BCG and appliedAI, where he worked on leveraging AI in procurement.”
About, investors	Visionaries Club, “a Berlin-based early stage VC fund backed by leading European digital founders and family business entrepreneurs”. UVC Partners, offering “strategic and operational support, as well as access to a vast network of corporate partners, experienced industry experts and international follow-on investors”
About, business angels	“Hanno Renner (Co-Founder Personio), Johannes Reck (Co-Founder GetYourGuide), Torsten Reil (Co-Founder NaturalMotion), and Michael Wax (Co-Founder Forto)”
About, jobs	“We are looking for passionate people in all departments to join us.”
Imprint	VAT number “wird nachgereicht” (to follow)
Not on the site	Product screens, a price, customers, partners

Source: tacto.ai, home page, About page and imprint, Internet Archive captures of 23 September 2020, see notes [4], [3] and [15]. Extracted by the case writer, links and e-mail addresses of individuals left out.

The Course's Hierarchy of Evidence



Endnotes

1. North Data, “Tacto Technology GmbH, München, Amtsgericht München HRB 257852”, register summary, https://www.northdata.com/Tacto+Technology+GmbH,+M%C3%BCnchen/Amtsgericht+M%C3%BCnchen+HRB+257852, accessed 2026-10-20. GLEIF, LEI record 391200E3BHFLNC1LR168, Tacto Technology GmbH, https://api.gleif.org/api/v1/lei-records/391200E3BHFLNC1LR168, accessed 2026-10-20.
2. deutsche-startups.de, “#EXKLUSIV Swiss Re investiert in Getsafe – bookingkit bekommt Millionen – Visionaries Club investiert in Tacto”, #DealMonitor, 7 September 2020, https://www.deutsche-startups.de/2020/09/07/dealmonitor-07-09-2020/, accessed 2026-10-20.
3. tacto.ai, About page, Internet Archive capture of 23 September 2020, https://web.archive.org/web/20200923102341/https://tacto.ai/about/, accessed 2026-10-20.
4. tacto.ai, home page, Internet Archive capture of 23 September 2020, https://web.archive.org/web/20200923095308/https://tacto.ai/, accessed 2026-10-20.
5. The case is set in late September 2020. No source dates a decision by the founders on a particular day. 23 September 2020 is the date of the first archived capture of the website, the latest document from the time that the case uses. The founders’ own accounts of the period were told in 2021 to 2023 and are marked as recollections.
6. Petry, Business Class #44, 0:19:26 to 0:19:35. Translated from German by the case writer.
7. Petry, Business Class #44, 0:18:49 to 0:19:06. Translated from German by the case writer.
8. André Petry in conversation with Tilo Bonow, “Macht KI Lieferketten nachhaltiger? André Petry, Tacto”, Business Class #44, video uploaded 4 April 2023, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=k518cwGbKhk, 0:09:02, accessed 2026-10-20. Translated from German by the case writer.
9. Petry, Business Class #44, 0:09:11 to 0:09:27. Translated from German by the case writer.
10. Alexander Hüsing and Sven Schmidt, “Insider #85”, ds-Insider-Podcast, deutsche-startups.de, 7 September 2020, https://www.deutsche-startups.de/2020/09/07/podcast-insider-85/, 0:12:11 to 0:12:20, accessed 2026-10-20. Translated from German by the case writer.
11. Center for Digital Technology and Management, startup profile “Tacto”, https://cdtm.com/startups/tacto, accessed 2026-10-20.
12. Simon Tischer, “Tacto: Einkaufsplattform für den Mittelstand”, written interview with Tacto, Munich Startup, 24 June 2022, https://www.munich-startup.de/news/tacto-einkaufsplattform-fuer-den-mittelstand, accessed 2026-10-20. Translated from German by the case writer. In a written interview with trans.info of 12 April 2022, Petry said the three had supported Mittelstand firms “in Digitalisierungsprojekten” (in digitalisation projects), without purchasing projects. Natalia Jakubowska, “Gründer-Interview mit André Petry von Tacto”, trans.info, https://trans.info/de/grunder-interview-tacto-284062, accessed 2026-10-20.
13. André Petry, pitch at the Procurement Summit Startup Awards, video uploaded 27 October 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tipytp9cKmw, 0:01:13 to 0:01:20, accessed 2026-10-20. Translated from German by the case writer.
14. André Petry in conversation with Startup Insider, “Tacto sammelt 5,3 Mio. Euro für Digitalisierung des Einkaufs ein”, video uploaded 25 March 2022, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TJaC4M7ZzGA, 0:23:43 to 0:24:06, accessed 2026-10-20. Translated from German by the case writer. One word, heard as “Pre-Seed” in one machine transcription and as “Privat” in the automatic captions, is cut.
15. tacto.ai, imprint, Internet Archive capture of 23 September 2020, https://web.archive.org/web/20200923093645/https://tacto.ai/imprint/, accessed 2026-10-20.